

Directory

Girolamo Frescobaldi

1583–1643, ITALIAN

Frescobaldi was one of the first great keyboard virtuosos (he played organ and harpsichord, as well as being a fine singer) and the first eminent composer to focus on music for an unaccompanied keyboard. He was born in Ferrara and spent most of his career in Rome, where he was organist at St. Peter's for most of the period from 1608 until his death (he had an interlude working at the Medici court in Florence from 1628 to 1634). During his lifetime, he was internationally famous, and his music continued to be admired and influential for several decades afterward (it was, for example, studied by the young J.S. Bach some 60 years later). His style was lively and inventive, often showing dramatic changes of tempo. In addition to keyboard works, he wrote sacred and secular vocal music and compositions for instrumental ensembles.
